

Roland's Home OT Manual

For Chrystal · Term 4 home programme · 9 weeks from Monday 5 October 2026

Based on Simóne Vorster's OT progress report (4 October 2026) and current paediatric OT guidance.

Roland turns 5 on 8 October. He is healthy, bright and **left-handed**. After 13 OT sessions he improved in every area. Therapy is paused for term 4, and the OT recommends support at home. That is this programme: about **20 minutes, 5 days a week**, movement first, short and successful table work, and a quick log after each session.



AREA (OT 1-5)	MAY	SEPT
Postural control & body awareness	3	4
Bilateral integration	3	4
Fine motor & visual perception	2	3

Goals and where he is now

AREA	GOAL	NOW (SEPT 2026)
BALANCE	Balance on each leg for 10 seconds with eyes closed.	Eyes open: 8 s on the right, 6 s on the left. He was hesitant to close his eyes. (May: 3 s eyes closed.)
STRONG BODY	Hold the full-body flexion 'egg' for 15 seconds.	10 s (was 8 s in May).
STRONG BODY	Sit upright at a table for 15–20 minutes without propping his head on his right hand.	Postural endurance still low; neck tires.
TWO HANDS	Cross the midline at the table without swapping the crayon to the other hand.	Mostly crosses, with effort. Swaps hands about 20% of the time; more consistent with his left.
TWO HANDS	10 smooth star jumps, then smooth hopscotch (legs open and closed).	10 star jumps achieved (speed varies). Hopscotch is next.
SCISSORS	Cut on straight lines with thumb facing up; helper hand feeds and turns the paper.	Straight lines improved; curves need refining; needs reminders to turn the paper instead of lifting his left shoulder.
PENCIL	Three-point (tripod) grasp with an open web space, not a thumb wrapped round the crayon.	Aware of a better grip, but needs prompting.
PENCIL	Colour without switching hands; more control moving the pencil from point to point.	Low finger endurance; not keen to colour for long. Still learning pencil control.
PENCIL	Copy shapes at his age level (was at about a 4-year level).	Next, in order: square, diagonal lines, X, triangle.

Typical at 5: about 10 s on one leg eyes open and about 27 s egg hold. Eyes-closed balance is much harder, so 10 s eyes closed is a stretch goal.

How a session works

WARM-UP · 2 MIN	BODY · 6 MIN	HANDS · 3 MIN	TABLE · 8 MIN	FINISH · 1 MIN
Wake up the body with heavy work before sitting down.	Core, balance or two-sided movement.	A quick finger warm-up. Keep it short: the table task is the real practice.	Cutting, pencil control or colouring. Check his set-up first.	He picks a favourite to repeat, then a sticker. Then you log the session (2 minutes).

- **Weeks 1-2: Settle in.** Learn the routine together. Use the standard version of each activity and keep it fun. Do the baseline check-in on Friday of week 1.
- **Weeks 3-6: Build.** Move an activity to its 'Harder' version once he has managed it well 2 sessions in a row. Change one thing at a time, and vary the paper, tools and surfaces.
- **Weeks 7-9: Stretch.** Push gently towards the goals: longer holds, eyes-closed balance, curved cutting, small colouring. The final check-in in week 9 goes to the OT.
- **Check-ins** (10 min, instead of the Body block): Friday of weeks 1, 3, 5, 7, 9.

Golden rules

- **Little and often.** About 20 minutes, 5 days a week. In a trial of parent-run OT home programmes, about 17 sessions a month of about 16 minutes worked.
- **Body before hands.** Always start with movement. Heavy work wakes up the core and shoulders so sitting and pencil work are easier.
- **Make it play.** Hide the exercise inside a game, story or job. Offer him a choice of 2 or 3 activities, colours or the order.
- **Aim for 4 out of 5.** He should succeed most of the time. Missing 3 or more out of 10: make it easier. Spot-on 2 sessions in a row: try the harder version.
- **One cue, same words.** Use the short cue words in this guide, one at a time. Talk about the result ('make the scissors walk on the road'), not his body parts. Get him to say the cue too.
- **Feedback: lots, then less.** With a new skill, tell him how he did on most tries. Once he has it, every second or third try, then a summary at the end.
- **Praise the effort.** 'You turned the paper with your helper hand!' works better than 'you're so clever'. Specific praise keeps him trying after mistakes.
- **Same skill, new look.** Once a skill is coming, vary it: different paper, crayons, chalk, a wall, the floor, the garden.
- **Stop before he's done.** Watch for the tired signs below and switch to a movement break. Always end on a success.
- **Set up for a lefty.** Left-handed scissors, paper to his left and tilted, light from his right, you on his right.
- **Log it.** Two minutes after each session. The log is how his parents and the OT see progress.

Weekly plan

The first activity in each cell is the default; the others are swaps. Full instructions are in the activity cards.

DAY	WARM-UP · 2	BODY · 6	HANDS · 3	TABLE · 8
Monday Strong body + scissors	Heavy-work helper Animal walk relay	Egg hold (rocket countdown) Superman / aeroplane Ball walk-outs	Playdough gym Peg it on	Curvy roads Road cutting Cut and make
Tuesday Crossing the middle + pencil control	Cross-crawl march Heavy-work helper	Cross-over sticker hunt Lazy-8 racetrack Ball pass and twist	Peg it on Tongs and tweezer transfer	Dot-to-dot Mazes and rainbow tracing Draw on the wall
Wednesday Balance + colouring stamina	Animal walk relay Heavy-work helper	Flamingo count Sleepy flamingo (eyes closed) Tightrope walk Freeze dance	Tongs and tweezer transfer Sensory treasure hunt	Small-picture colouring Paint and dot Draw on the wall
Thursday Two hands together + scissors	Star jumps Cross-crawl march	Hopscotch Balloon tennis Beanbag target throw	Geoboard patterns Punch and lace	Cut and make Snip snip Curvy roads
Friday Fun Friday: obstacle course + drawing	Obstacle course Animal walk relay	Tall-kneeling station Ball sitting and reaching Floor is lava	Squirrel stash (coins) Hammer and golf tees	How-to-draw videos Shape of the week Draw on the wall

Weekend: family play. Park: monkey bars, climbing frames, pumping his legs on the swing, slides. Swimming, riding a bike or scooter, kicking and catching a ball. Baking: stirring, rolling dough, cutting soft food with a butter knife, cracking eggs. Garden: digging, watering with a spray bottle or watering can, pulling weeds. Bath time: squeeze sponges, squirt toys, draw on the tiles with bath crayons or foam. Games with small pieces: Pick-up sticks, Jenga, Connect 4, Operation, Lego.

Everyday sneak-ins

- Carry the shopping bags, push the trolley, carry the washing basket.
- Spray-bottle the plants; squeeze the bath sponge; open his own lunch box and yoghurt.
- Tear lettuce, roll pastry, cut banana with a butter knife, stir the batter while holding the bowl.
- Do up his own buttons and zips; put on socks standing on one leg.
- Lie on his tummy to watch TV or read a story.
- Set the table: plates on one side, cutlery reaching across.
- Peel stickers, open pegs, post letters, push coins into the parking machine.

Table set-up for a left-hander

1. **Paper** on his left, turned clockwise 30–45°: top of the page leans right, left corner higher, bottom-right corner near his middle. The side of the page lines up with his left forearm. Mark

the angle with tape.

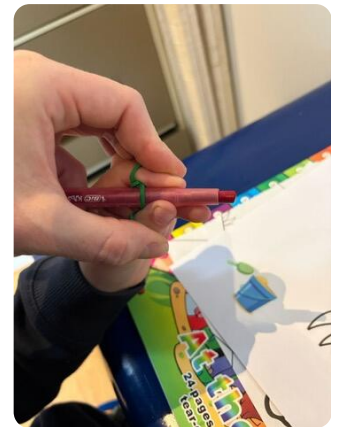
2. **Left forearm** along the page, wrist straight and **below** the line (not hooked). Pencil held 2–3 cm from the tip.
3. **Helper hand** (right) holds the page and slides it up. **Light** from his right.
4. **Chair:** feet flat (step stool), hips/knees/ankles at right angles, table about 5 cm above his bent elbow. A slant board helps.
5. **You:** facing him to show a grip or scissors (mirror); on his right when drawing together. At shared tables he sits at the left end.
6. **Scissors:** true left-handed (blades reversed). Left-handers cut circles clockwise.

Check with the OT: the report says "rotate the page 45 degrees to the left". In standard wording that is the right-hander's tilt. She most likely meant the page on his left with the left corner raised, as above. Send Simóne a photo to confirm.

Pencil grip

Now: thumb wraps round the crayon, web space closed. **Goal:** a three- or four-finger pinch with a round open "O" between thumb and pointer finger. A still grip is normal at 4–6; the moving tripod comes at about 6–7. The tight thumb-wrap is the one to change.

- Broken crayons under 3 cm; short, golf or triangular pencils.
- Pompom under the ring and little fingers; a sticker where the pointer goes; the OT's elastic loop (photo).
- Upright surfaces; finger warm-up first.
- **Set the grip at the start**, don't interrupt mid-drawing, check at natural pauses, one word or a silent "O" signal, praise self-correction.



Cue words

"Pinch the tip and flip"	Picking up a pencil or crayon: pinch near the point, flip it back into his hand.
"Show me your O"	Open web space: the gap between thumb and pointer finger makes a round O.
"Thumbs up!"	Scissors: thumb in the top hole, pointing at the ceiling.
"Helper hand turns the paper"	Cutting curves: his right hand turns the paper, not his left shoulder.
"Feet flat, bottom back, sit tall"	Before every table task.
"Shake, squeeze, same hand"	Hand tired while colouring: a quick hand break instead of swapping hands.
"Chin to chest, tight little egg"	Egg hold.
"Eyes on the sticker"	Flamingo balance.

Scissor ladder (he is at step 3-4)

STEP	EXAMPLES	AGE
1. Snip	Playdough, straws, card strips	about 2½-3
2. Fringe	Cut a fringe along a strip	about 3
3. Straight line	Thick road → thin line	about 3½-4
4. Curves & corners	Waves, zigzags, big circle	about 4-4½
5. Simple shapes	Square, triangle, circle	about 4½-5
6. Pictures	Cut out a printed picture	about 5-6

Shape copying by age (copy, don't trace)

SHAPE	AGE
vertical line	2
— horizontal line	3
O circle	3
+ cross	4
□ square	4½
/ \ diagonals	4½
X	5
△ triangle	5¼
◇ diamond	6-8

Activity cards

STRONG BODY

Core strength, posture and body awareness

Egg hold (rocket countdown)

Builds the front core muscles he needs to sit tall. OT goal: 15 seconds.

1. Lie on his back on a rug.
2. Hug his knees, tuck his chin to his chest and lift his head and shoulders off the floor: a tight little egg.
3. Hold while you count down from 10 like a rocket. Shout 'blast off!' and relax.
4. Rest as long as the hold, then go again.

Say: "Chin to chest, tight little egg!"

Easier: Let him rock gently in the egg for 5 rocks, or hold with your hand behind his head.

Harder: Arms crossed on his chest, then a 'banana boat' with arms and legs stretched out just off the floor.

How much: 3-5 holds. Add 2-3 s only after 2 sessions in a row with good form.

You need: Rug or mat

Superman / aeroplane

Strengthens the back and neck muscles that stop him slumping and propping his head.

1. Lie on his tummy.
2. Lift arms, head, chest and legs together, eyes looking at the floor just ahead.
3. 'Fly' to a place he chooses while you count.
4. Land, rest, fly again.

Say: "Fly to Cape Town! Arms up, legs up!"

Easier: Lift arms and head only, then legs only.

Harder: Hold a beanbag in his hands, or turn his head slowly side to side while flying.

How much: 3-5 holds of 5 → 15 s.

You need: Rug or mat

Ball walk-outs

Weight through the arms builds shoulder stability for pencil control.



1. He lies tummy-down over a gym ball.
2. He walks forward on his hands until the ball is under his thighs.
3. He picks up a toy or puzzle piece and drops it in a bucket.
4. Walks back, collects the next one.

Say: "Strong arms, straight back."

Easier: Ball stays under his tummy; you hold his hips.

Harder: Walk further out so the ball is under his knees; reach to the sides.

How much: 5-10 items.

You need: Gym ball (55 cm) or a firm ottoman

Tummy-time play

Lying on elbows builds neck and shoulder strength without him noticing.



1. He lies on his tummy propped on his elbows.
2. Do a puzzle, Lego, a book or drawing on a clipboard on the floor.
3. Use this for TV or story time too.

Say: "Elbows under your shoulders."

Easier: Pillow under his chest.

Harder: No pillow; reach out with one arm to place pieces.

How much: 5–10 minutes a day.

You need: Clipboard, puzzle

Animal walk relay

Heavy work for arms, shoulders and core; a great warm-up before table work.

1. Set up a start and finish line in the passage or garden.
2. Bear walk (hands and feet, bottom up), crab walk (tummy up), frog jumps, wheelbarrow.
3. Carry a beanbag or puzzle piece across each time to build a picture at the end.

Say: "Big strong bear!"

Easier: Short distance; wheelbarrow held at his hips or thighs.

Harder: Wheelbarrow held at his knees; crab walk with a beanbag on his tummy; walk on grass or up a slope.

How much: 3–4 lengths of about 5 m.

You need: None (beanbag optional)

Heavy-work helper

Pushing, pulling and carrying tell the body where it is, and help him feel calm and alert.

1. Pick one job: wall push-ups, pushing a laundry basket of books, carrying the shopping, towel tug-of-war.
2. Do it for 2–3 minutes.
3. Finish with 10 wall push-ups: 'push the wall over'.

Say: "Push the wall over!"

Easier: Lighter loads.

Harder: Heavier basket; chair push-ups (hands on seat, lift his bottom, hold 5 s).

How much: 2–3 minutes before every table session.

You need: Household items

Tall-kneeling station

Kneeling up straight trains the hips and trunk to hold him upright.



1. He kneels tall at the coffee table or sofa: hips straight, not sitting back on his heels.
2. Play a game there: post coins into a piggy bank, stickers, a puzzle.
3. Swap to half-kneeling (one knee up) halfway.

Say: "Tall like a tree."

Easier: Hands may rest on the sofa.

Harder: Kneel on a pillow; tap a balloon with nothing to hold on to.

How much: 3–5 minutes.

You need: Cushion for his knees, coins and a piggy bank

Ball sitting and reaching

Sitting on a moving ball makes the core work while he reaches and turns.



1. He sits on a gym ball, feet flat, knees bent at 90°.
2. Stick sticky notes or stickers on a window or wall at different heights and sides.
3. He reaches, peels them off and puts them in a jar.

Say: "Feet flat, sit tall."

Easier: You hold his hips; use a wobble cushion on a chair instead.

Harder: Lift one foot; reach across his body to the far side.

How much: 3–5 minutes.

You need: Gym ball or wobble cushion, sticky notes

Obstacle course

Combines crawling, balance, jumping and heavy work in one game he plans himself.



1. Build a loop: crawl under chairs, step on cushion stones, bear-walk, walk a tape line.
2. Finish with a 5-second egg hold at the end.
3. Let him redesign it for round two.

Say: "Your turn to be the boss of the course."

Easier: Fewer stations, more space.

Harder: Carry a beanbag on his head, or add a one-leg stop.

How much: 3–4 rounds.

You need: Cushions, chairs, masking tape, blanket

Crawl and cat-cow

Movement play the OT linked to his reflex goal. Treat it as general motor play: the research is weak.

1. Lizard crawl: commando crawl on his tummy, head turning to the side of the bending arm.
2. On hands and knees, slowly turn his head left and right with elbows straight.
3. Cat-cow: look up and dip the back, look down and round the back. Then rock back to his heels and forward.

Say: "Slow, like a sleepy cat."

Easier: Short distances, 3 reps.

Harder: Hold each position 5 s; lift one arm in cat-cow.

How much: 3–5 minutes, 8–10 reps.

You need: Rug

Flamingo count

Builds the standing balance he needs. Left leg first: it is the weaker side (6 s vs 8 s).

1. Barefoot, hands on hips, eyes on a sticker on the wall.
2. Lift one foot and count out loud together.
3. Take turns: you do it too.
4. Swap legs. Best of 3 tries.

Say: "Eyes on the sticker, still as a flamingo."

Easier: One fingertip on the wall.

Harder: Stand on a folded towel or cushion, or catch a balloon while balancing.

How much: 3–5 tries per leg.

You need: Sticker on the wall

Sleepy flamingo (eyes closed)

The OT goal is 10 s per leg with eyes closed. He was hesitant, so build trust step by step.

1. Start with eyes closed on two feet for 10 s.
2. Then on one leg with your hands hovering at his hips.
3. Count out loud so he knows how long is left: 2 s, 3 s, then 5 s.
4. Step down your support: hold his hand → one finger → hands hovering → no help.

Say: "Sleepy flamingo, I've got you."

Easier: Look up at the ceiling instead of closing his eyes.

Harder: Eyes closed for longer; later on a towel.

How much: 3 tries per leg, only after a warm-up. Stand in a corner or next to the sofa.

You need: Clear floor, soft surface nearby

Freeze dance

Balance practice that feels like a party.

1. Play music and dance.
2. When the music stops he freezes: two feet → tiptoes → one leg.
3. Call out which leg: 'left flamingo!'

Say: "Freeze! Left leg up!"

Easier: Freeze on two feet.

Harder: Freeze on one leg with eyes closed.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Music

Tightrope walk

Balance while moving, plus body awareness of where his feet are.

1. Put a 2–3 m line of masking tape on the floor (or a plank).
2. Walk forwards heel-to-toe, then backwards, then sideways.
3. Stop halfway and stand on one leg.

Say: "Heel touches toe."

Easier: Wide tape, normal steps.

Harder: Beanbag on his head, step over toys on the line, or use a plank.

How much: 5–10 lengths.

You need: Masking tape or a plank

Floor is lava

Jumping and landing on small targets trains balance and control.

1. Lay cushions or paper plates as stepping stones.
2. He steps or jumps across without touching the 'lava'.
3. Add a hop between some stones.

Say: "Land like a cat, quiet feet."

Easier: Stones close together and firm.

Harder: Bigger gaps, soft cushions, hop on one foot.

How much: 3–5 rounds.

You need: Cushions or paper plates

Hop count and sock challenge

Hopping and dressing on one leg are everyday balance tests.

1. Hop on one foot, counting: 5 hops, then 10. Each foot.
2. Put on socks and shoes standing up.

Say: "Bounce, bounce, bounce!"

Easier: Lean on the wall to dress.

Harder: Hop forwards and backwards over a line.

How much: Daily when dressing.

You need: None

Hopscotch

The OT's next bilateral goal after star jumps.

1. Step 1: on the spot, jump feet together and apart to a rhythm: 'close, open'.
2. Step 2: chalk or tape a grid of single and double squares.
3. Step 3: the full game, hopping in singles and landing open in doubles.

Say: "Close, open, close, open!"

Easier: Two-foot jumps only; you jump beside him.

Harder: Pick up a stone while on one leg; go faster.

How much: 3–5 rounds.

You need: Chalk or masking tape

Star jumps

He can do 10 now. Keep it smooth and steady, then add arms.

1. 10 star jumps with legs only to a count.
2. Then add arms in time with the legs.
3. Try to music.

Say: "Out, in, out, in."

Easier: Arms only, then legs only.

Harder: Cross jacks (legs cross in front), or 3 sets of 10.

How much: 3 × 5–10.

You need: None

Cross-crawl march

Hand to opposite knee gets both sides of the body talking across the middle.

1. March on the spot, touching right hand to left knee, left hand to right knee.
2. Then elbow to opposite knee.
3. Then hand to opposite foot behind his back.

Say: "Hand to the other knee."

Easier: Go slowly; you mirror him.

Harder: Faster, to a song.

How much: 1–2 minutes (10–20 touches).

You need: Music

Cross-over sticker hunt

Reaching across his body and turning his trunk: what the OT asked for.

1. He sits cross-legged or kneels tall.
2. Put stickers on his right arm and leg, or toys on his right side.
3. He collects them with his LEFT hand and sticks them on a board on his left side.

Say: "Left hand goes on a trip."

Easier: Items close to his body.

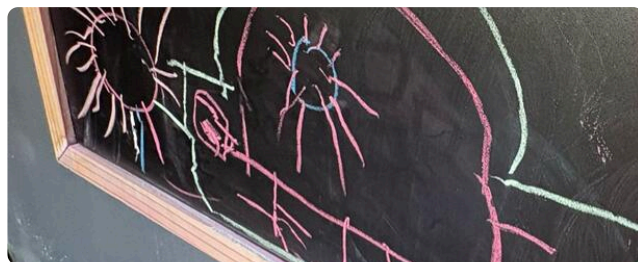
Harder: Items further away and behind him; you pass items from behind his back.

How much: 10–20 items.

You need: Stickers, small toys

Lazy-8 racetrack

A sideways 8 crosses the middle every lap and trains smooth pencil control.



1. Draw a big sideways 8 on paper taped to the wall, a chalkboard or a window, centred in front of him.
2. He drives a toy car round it, then traces with chalk or crayon.
3. Left hand, right hand, then both hands together.

Say: "Stay on the road."

Easier: Trace over a thick line.

Harder: Draw it freely; make it smaller.

How much: 5–10 laps.

You need: Chalk, crayon, toy car

Ball pass and twist

Trunk rotation, the second half of the OT's midline advice.

1. Pass a ball around his waist, over his head and under his legs.
2. Sit back to back with him and pass the ball to the side, twisting.
3. Windmills: feet apart, touch hand to opposite foot.

Say: "Twist and pass."

Easier: Big ball, slow.

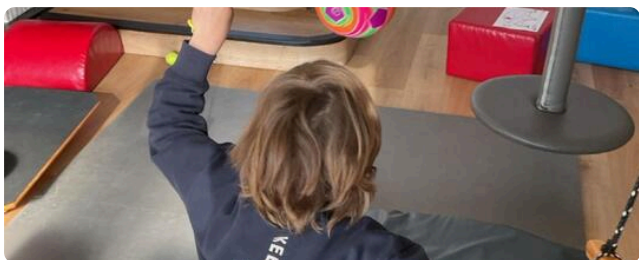
Harder: Smaller ball, faster, count passes.

How much: 10 passes each way.

You need: Ball

Balloon tennis

Eye-hand coordination and taking turns between hands.



1. Keep a balloon in the air with a racquet or paper-plate paddle.
2. Then strictly alternate hands.
3. Try it kneeling.

Say: "Left, right, left!"

Easier: Any hand, any time.

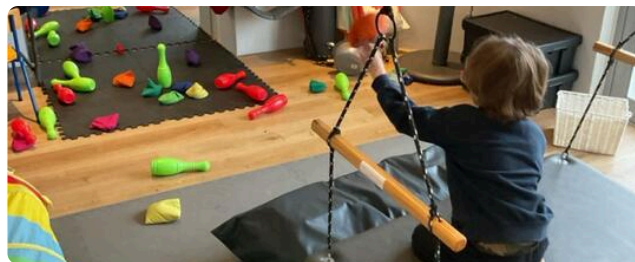
Harder: Two hands on a pool noodle; count hits.

How much: 2-3 minutes.

You need: Balloon, kids' racquet or paper plate

Beanbag target throw

Aiming and throwing across his body.



1. Set up skittles, bottles or a bucket.
2. He kneels and throws beanbags at the targets.
3. Alternate hands; throw across his body.

Say: "Look, aim, throw."

Easier: Closer and bigger targets.

Harder: Further away; throw while standing on one leg.

How much: 10 throws.

You need: Beanbags, skittles or bottles

Scooter board

Both arms working together while the core holds him up.



1. He sits or lies on his tummy on the scooter board.
2. Pushes with both hands to collect beanbags across the room.
3. Or pulls himself along a rope tied to a table leg.

Say: "Both hands push together."

Easier: Sitting, short distance.

Harder: Lying on his tummy; pulling hand over hand.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Scooter board (nice-to-have)

Two-hand kitchen jobs

Real jobs where one hand holds and the other works.

1. Roll dough with a rolling pin.
2. Pour from a jug into a cup he holds.
3. Stir while holding the bowl; spread butter while holding the bread; open jars.

Say: "Helper hand holds, busy hand works."

Easier: Small amounts, big cups.

Harder: Pour to a line; open tight lids.

How much: Any day.

You need: Kitchen

STRONG HANDS Finger strength and staying power

Playdough gym

Strengthens the small muscles in the hand, so colouring lasts longer.

1. Roll tiny balls between thumb, pointer and middle fingertips.
2. Roll snakes, pinch pots, poke holes with each finger.
3. Hide beads or coins inside and dig them out.
4. Snip the snakes with his scissors.

Say: "Use your fingertips."

Easier: Soft dough.

Harder: Firmer dough or therapy putty; smaller beads.

How much: 3–5 minutes.

You need: Play-Doh or therapy putty, beads

Peg it on

Pinching pegs builds the thumb–finger pinch used for a pencil.

1. Clip pegs onto a paper plate, box rim or card.
2. Match colours or numbers.
3. Use thumb and pointer finger, then thumb and middle finger.

Say: "Pinch with your pointer and thumb."

Easier: Loose pegs.

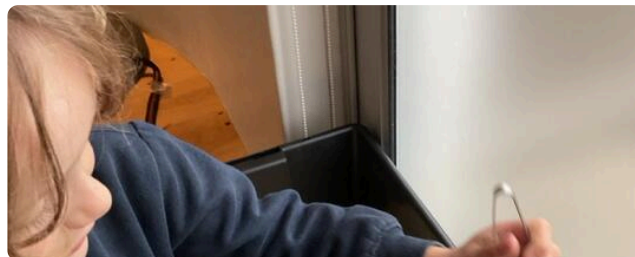
Harder: Stiff pegs; pick up pompoms with a peg.

How much: 10–20 pegs.

You need: Wooden pegs

Tongs and tweezer transfer

Squeezing tweezers builds pinch strength; holding them like a pencil practises the grip.



1. Fill a tray with rice or beans and hide pompoms or marbles.
2. He picks them out with tongs or tweezers and drops them in a bucket or ice-cube tray.
3. Hold the tweezers like a pencil.

Say: "Hold them like your crayon."

Easier: Big tongs, big pompoms.

Harder: Small tweezers, beans or cereal; beat a 1-minute timer.

How much: 2–3 minutes.

You need: Tongs or tweezers, rice tray, pompoms

Geoboard patterns

Stretching bands strengthens fingers; copying patterns trains seeing shapes.



1. Put rubber bands on the geoboard pegs.
2. Copy a pattern card.
3. Make his own shape for you to copy.

Say: "Stretch and hook."

Easier: Free designs with big bands.

Harder: Copy harder cards; small bands.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Geoboard and bands

Punch and lace

Hole punching builds strength; lacing gets two hands working together.



1. Punch holes around a paper plate or a coloured picture.
2. Lace wool or a shoelace through the holes.
3. Or thread beads on a lace or pipe cleaner.

Say: "In and out, like sewing."

Easier: Big beads on a pipe cleaner.

Harder: Small beads; follow a colour pattern.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Hole punch, laces, beads

Spray-bottle jobs

Squeezing a trigger builds strength in the pointer and middle fingers.

1. Water the plants, spray chalk drawings off the paving, or knock ping-pong balls off a ledge.
2. Use two fingers on the trigger.

Say: "Two fingers squeeze."

Easier: Big trigger, whole hand.

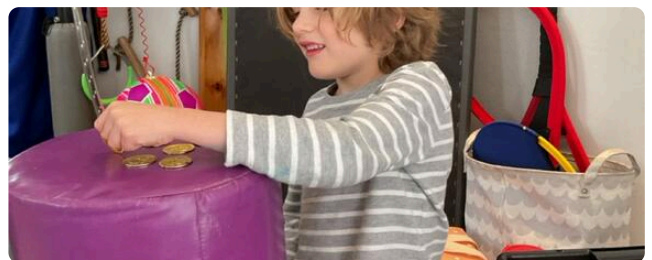
Harder: Small trigger, small targets.

How much: 2-3 minutes.

You need: Spray bottle

Squirrel stash (coins)

Moving coins from palm to fingertips in one hand: a key skill for handling a pencil.



1. He picks up coins one at a time and hides them in his left palm.
2. Then feeds them one by one into a piggy bank, using only that hand.
3. Flip a coin over with fingertips, then post it.

Say: "Squirrel hides the nuts."

Easier: Two big buttons.

Harder: 5 or more small coins.

How much: 3 rounds.

You need: Coins, piggy bank

Hammer and golf tees

Helper hand holds, busy hand taps: strength and two-hand teamwork.



1. Push golf tees into a polystyrene block, cardboard box or thick playdough.
2. Tap them in with a toy hammer.
3. Or use a tap-tap shapes kit.

Say: "Hold with your fingertips, tap gently."

Easier: Tees pre-started.

Harder: Pull them out with his fingertips; make a pattern.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Golf tees, toy hammer, polystyrene

Sensory treasure hunt

Finding small things in foam, rice or beans uses fingertips and finger isolation.



1. Hide small toys in shaving foam, rice or dry beans.
2. He finds them with his fingers only.
3. Sort them into an ice-cube tray.

Say: "Detective fingers."

Easier: Bigger toys.

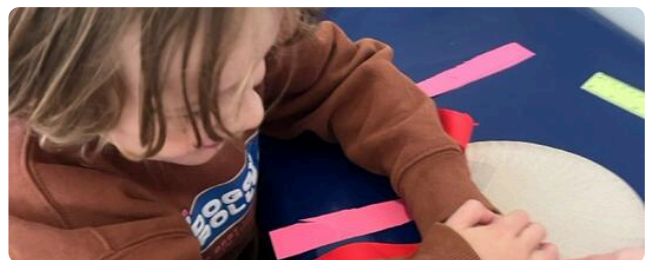
Harder: Tiny items; use tweezers.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Shaving foam, rice or beans, small toys

Tear and stick collage

Tearing small pieces uses both hands and the fingertip pinch.



1. Tear coloured paper into strips, then small pieces.
2. Glue them inside an outline to make a picture.
3. Peel and stick stickers too.

Say: "Thumbs on top, tear small."

Easier: Thin paper, big pieces.

Harder: Card; tiny pieces; small outline.

How much: 5-10 minutes.

You need: Coloured paper, glue stick, stickers

Snip snip

Short, single snips build the open-shut action and confidence.

1. Snip playdough snakes into pieces.
2. Snip straws into 'beads' to thread later.
3. Snip card strips 2 cm wide into confetti.

Say: "Thumbs up! Open, shut."

Easier: Playdough, then straws.

Harder: Wider strips that need two snips.

How much: 20 snips.

You need: Left-handed scissors, playdough, straws, card

Road cutting

Straight lines first, with the thumb up and the helper hand holding.

1. Draw a thick 1 cm 'road' on card.
2. He cuts down the middle of the road.
3. Helper hand holds the card at the edge, thumb on top.
4. Progress: 10 cm long → across an A4 page; thick → thin lines.

Say: "Thumbs up, stay on the road."

Easier: Card instead of paper; shorter roads.

Harder: Thinner lines, ordinary paper, longer lines.

How much: 3–5 lines.

You need: Left-handed scissors, card, thick marker

Curvy roads

Curves are his next step. The helper hand must turn the paper, not his shoulder.



1. Draw gentle waves, then zigzag mountains, then a big circle.
2. His scissor hand stays thumbs-up with the elbow at his side.
3. His helper hand (right) turns the paper as he goes.
4. Lefties cut circles clockwise: draw arrows to show the way.

Say: "Helper hand turns the paper."

Easier: Wide curves on card.

Harder: Tighter curves, smaller circles, thin paper.

How much: 3–5 lines.

You need: Left-handed scissors, card

Cut and make

Cutting with a purpose: a picture or craft to keep.



1. Cut a big square, triangle and circle from card.
2. Glue them into a picture: house, rocket, robot.
3. Later: cut pictures out of catalogues or colouring sheets.

Say: "Turn the paper, not your body."

Easier: Bigger shapes, wide border.

Harder: Smaller shapes, cut right on the line.

How much: 1 craft.

You need: Left-handed scissors, card, glue

PENCIL Grip, control, colouring and shapes

Dot-to-dot

The OT's top tip for getting him keen to draw.
Moving point to point builds pencil control.



1. Start with a 1-10 dot-to-dot with big dots.
2. Or draw a simple picture in dots for him (a house, a car, a fish).
3. He joins them, then colours it in.

Say: "Pinch the tip, go dot to dot."

Easier: Fewer dots, close together.

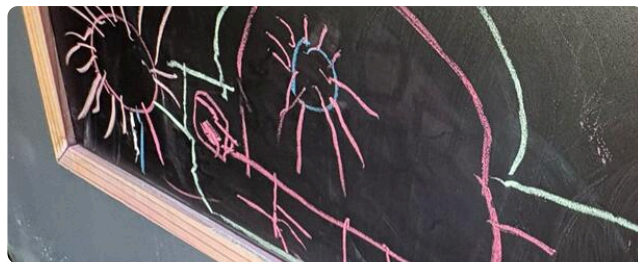
Harder: 1-20, then 1-50; smaller dots.

How much: 1-2 sheets.

You need: Dot-to-dot book, short crayon or pencil

Draw on the wall

Drawing on an upright surface bends the wrist back and strengthens the shoulder: both help the grip.



1. Tape paper to the wall or fridge at eye level, or use a chalkboard, easel or window markers.
2. Big shapes, lazy-8s, roads and houses.
3. Then smaller shapes inside a boundary.

Say: "Stand tall, small chalk."

Easier: Big strokes, big chalk.

Harder: Small chalk pieces; colour inside shapes.

How much: 5 minutes.

You need: Chalkboard or easel, chalk, tape

Mazes and rainbow tracing

Stopping and steering inside a path is pencil control.



1. Wide mazes first: drive a toy car through, then trace with a crayon.
2. Rainbow trace: go over the same line 3-5 times in different colours.
3. Line-matching puzzles (like the OT's 'focus challenge').

Say: "Slow car, stay inside."

Easier: 2 cm wide paths.

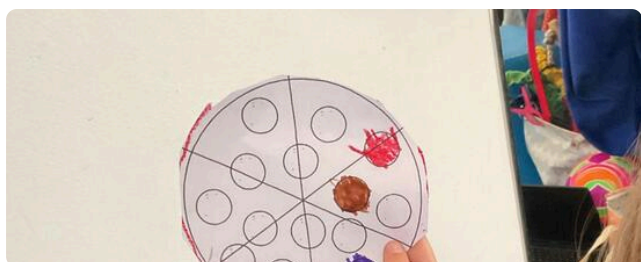
Harder: 5 mm paths, longer mazes.

How much: 1-3 mazes.

You need: Maze book, crayons

Small-picture colouring

Small pictures build finger stamina with a quick win. OT advice.



1. Choose a picture about the size of a playing card, with thick outlines.
2. Set the visual timer: 3 minutes, then build to 5 and 8.
3. Use broken crayons under 3 cm long.
4. If he swaps hands, say calmly 'left hand draws, right hand helps' and hand the crayon back. If he swaps again within a minute, he is tired: stop and move.
5. Put the crayon pot on his right so he reaches across his body.

Say: "Shake, squeeze, same hand."

Easier: Raised outline (dried glue or a playdough snake) he can feel.

Harder: Smaller areas, mandalas, colour-by-number.

How much: Start at a length he manages without swapping (2-3 minutes). Add 1 minute after 3 good sessions.

You need: Small colouring pictures, short crayons, visual timer

Paint and dot

A brush or cotton bud needs a fingertip grip and a light touch.



1. Paint rainbow arcs with watercolours.
2. Dot-paint with cotton buds inside circles.
3. Hold the brush low, near the bristles.

Say: "Pinch near the bristles."

Easier: Thick brush, big paper.

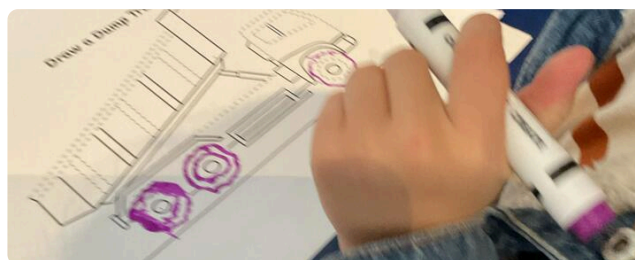
Harder: Thin brush, stay inside lines.

How much: 5-10 minutes.

You need: Watercolours, cotton buds

How-to-draw videos

The OT recommends these to make drawing fun. Step-by-step drawing practises shapes and control.



1. Choose a short video, e.g. Art for Kids Hub on YouTube.
2. Pause after each step so he can finish it.
3. Draw alongside him.

Say: "Pause, draw, play."

Easier: Very simple animals and vehicles.

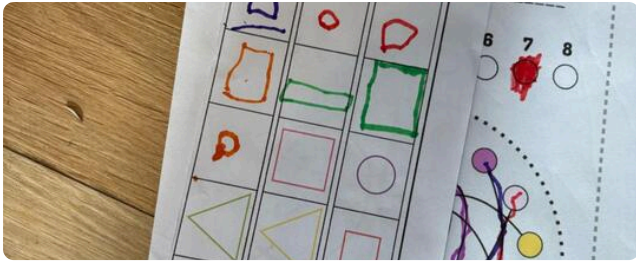
Harder: More detailed drawings, then colour them.

How much: 1 drawing, 10-15 minutes.

You need: Tablet or laptop, paper, short pencil

Shape of the week

Copying shapes is the OT's visual-motor goal (he was at about a 4-year level).



1. Order: + → square → / and \ → X → triangle. Say the strokes: square is 'down, across, down, across'.
2. Make it big first: finger in shaving foam, chalk on the wall, sticks on the floor.
3. Then on paper: you draw it, he copies next to yours (copy, don't trace).
4. Turn it into a picture: a square becomes a house.

Say: "Start at the top."

Easier: Watch you draw it, then copy straight away.

Harder: Copy from a finished picture; combine shapes into a robot.

How much: 5 shapes.

You need: Paper, sticks, chalk

Stencils

The helper hand holds the stencil firmly while the busy hand traces.



1. Helper hand presses the stencil flat.
2. He traces inside the shape with a short pencil.
3. Colour it in.

Say: "Helper hand holds it still."

Easier: Big simple stencils.

Harder: Small or detailed stencils.

How much: 3-4 shapes.

You need: Stencils, short pencil

When to stop

Tired signs

- Propping his head on his hand or lying on the table
- Slumping, wriggling off the chair, kneeling on the chair
- Switching the crayon to the other hand
- Grip gets tighter, lines get wobbly, presses very hard or very light
- Rushing, scribbling, silliness or tears

Switch to a movement break, then finish with something easy. Never push through tears.

Safety

- Balance work barefoot, clear floor, next to a sofa, your hands hovering at his hips.
- Stay within reach on the gym ball.
- Wheelbarrow held at thighs or knees.
- Count out loud during holds so he keeps breathing.

Tell Roland's parents (they'll check with the OT)

- Any pain, dizziness or a fall during an exercise
- He refuses or gets very upset for several sessions in a row
- No progress on a goal after about 4 weeks of regular practice
- Before buying a pencil grip or special pencil: the OT said one may help in Grade R and should be monitored
- Before trying to sort out his handwriting letters: shapes come first at this age

Shopping list

Approximate prices, researched 5 October 2026.

Must-haves (about R2 445)

	ITEM	WHERE	EST.
☐	Left-handed scissors (true left-handed, blades reversed) The most important buy. With right-handed or 'both-hands' scissors he can't see the line and the blades push apart.	Takealot: Pelikan Griffix left-handed, about R99. Budget: RGS Group left-hand 135 mm, about R35. Buy 2.	R134
☐	Therapy putty (soft) + Play-Doh 4-pack Hand strengthening: rolling, pinching, hidden beads.	HiTech Therapy online: soft therapy putty about R78. Takealot or Toys R Us: Play-Doh 4-pack about R119.	R197
☐	Fine-motor tool set (tweezers, tongs, dropper) Pincer strength and practising the pencil grip.	Takealot: Learning Resources Helping Hands Fine Motor Tool Set, about R319. Kitchen tongs work to start.	R319
☐	Wooden pegs (100) Pinch strength.	Takealot, Crazy Store or Pick n Pay: about R55-R96.	R70

☐	Geoboard with rubber bands and pattern cards Finger strength and copying patterns, like at OT.	Takealot: Smartplay geoboard about R95, or TookyToy geoboard set about R229.	R95
☐	Threading beads and laces Two hands together, eye-hand coordination.	Takealot: RGS Group threading beads (48 pcs) about R75.	R75
☐	Short and chunky drawing tools Short, triangular tools encourage a fingertip grip. Snap crayons in half on purpose.	PNA, CNA, Waltons or Takealot: triangular jumbo wax crayons about R48, Staedtler jumbo beginner pencils about R26, Maped triangular colour pencils about R81, Crayola washable markers about R120, sidewalk chalk about R66, golf pencils about R30.	R371
☐	Visual timer Same tool the OT uses. He can see how long is left, which helps him keep going. (This page also has a timer.)	Takealot: kids' rainbow visual timer about R198; Time Timer about R450.	R198
☐	Cutting, maze and dot-to-dot books Ready-made, graded practice pages.	Takealot, Exclusive Books or PNA: Kumon My First Book of Cutting about R185, Kumon My First Book of Mazes about R140, a dot-to-dot book about R100. Free printables online too.	R425
☐	Hole punch, stickers, spray bottle Hand strength jobs.	Crazy Store, Clicks or PNA: single-hole punch about R27, stickers about R45, spray bottle about R30.	R102
☐	A4 clipboard + tabletop easel / chalkboard An angled or upright surface helps a left-hander keep the wrist straight and builds shoulder strength. Clip the clipboard to a lever-arch file for a DIY slant board.	Takealot: A4 masonite clipboard about R31; 2-in-1 whiteboard/chalkboard easel about R269.	R300
☐	Footrest (step stool) for the table Feet flat with hips and knees at 90° gives him a stable base for sitting upright.	Takealot: kids' step stool about R159, or a sturdy box. Full option: kids' table and chair about R800.	R159

Nice-to-haves (about R2 554)

	ITEM	WHERE	EST.
☐	Gym ball (45-55 cm, anti-burst) + wobble cushion Core work while sitting and reaching.	Takealot or Sportsmans Warehouse: anti-burst gym ball with pump about R198; balance disc wobble cushion about R219.	R417
☐	Scooter board Core and shoulder strength; he loved it at OT.	Tiny Tree Toys (OT-owned SA shop): 40 × 30 cm about R596.	R596
☐	Balance beam or stepping stones	Takealot: foam balance beam about R349, or stepping stones about R309.	R349

	Balance practice. Masking tape on the floor works too.		
☐	Beanbags, cones, balloons, ribbon wand, kids' racquet Throwing, aiming, balloon tennis, crossing the middle.	Takealot: cones + beanbags + ring toss set about R299; balloons, ribbon wands and racquets from Crazy Store, Game or Sportsmans.	R550
☐	Play tunnel + folding foam mat Crawling, obstacle courses, a soft landing for balance work.	Takealot: play tunnel about R223; folding foam play mat about R299.	R522
☐	Storage box for the kit Everything in one place, quick to set out.	Crazy Store, Mr Price Home or Game: clear lidded box about R80-R150.	R120

Check with Simóne first

	ITEM	WHERE	EST.
☐	Pencil grip or left-handed pencil Ask the OT first. She said a grip may help in Grade R and should be monitored. The wrong grip can fix a poor grasp in place.	Takealot: Crossover pencil grip x3 about R111; STABILO EASYgraph left-handed pencils about R155-R213.	R111

Already in the house: Kitchen tongs, ice-cube tray, egg boxes · Rice, dry beans, pasta, cereal · Shaving foam · Cotton buds, straws, paper plates · Old catalogues, cereal boxes (for card) · Masking tape, glue stick · Coins and a piggy bank · Golf tees and a polystyrene block · Sponges, bubble wrap, balloons · A cushion pile and a blanket